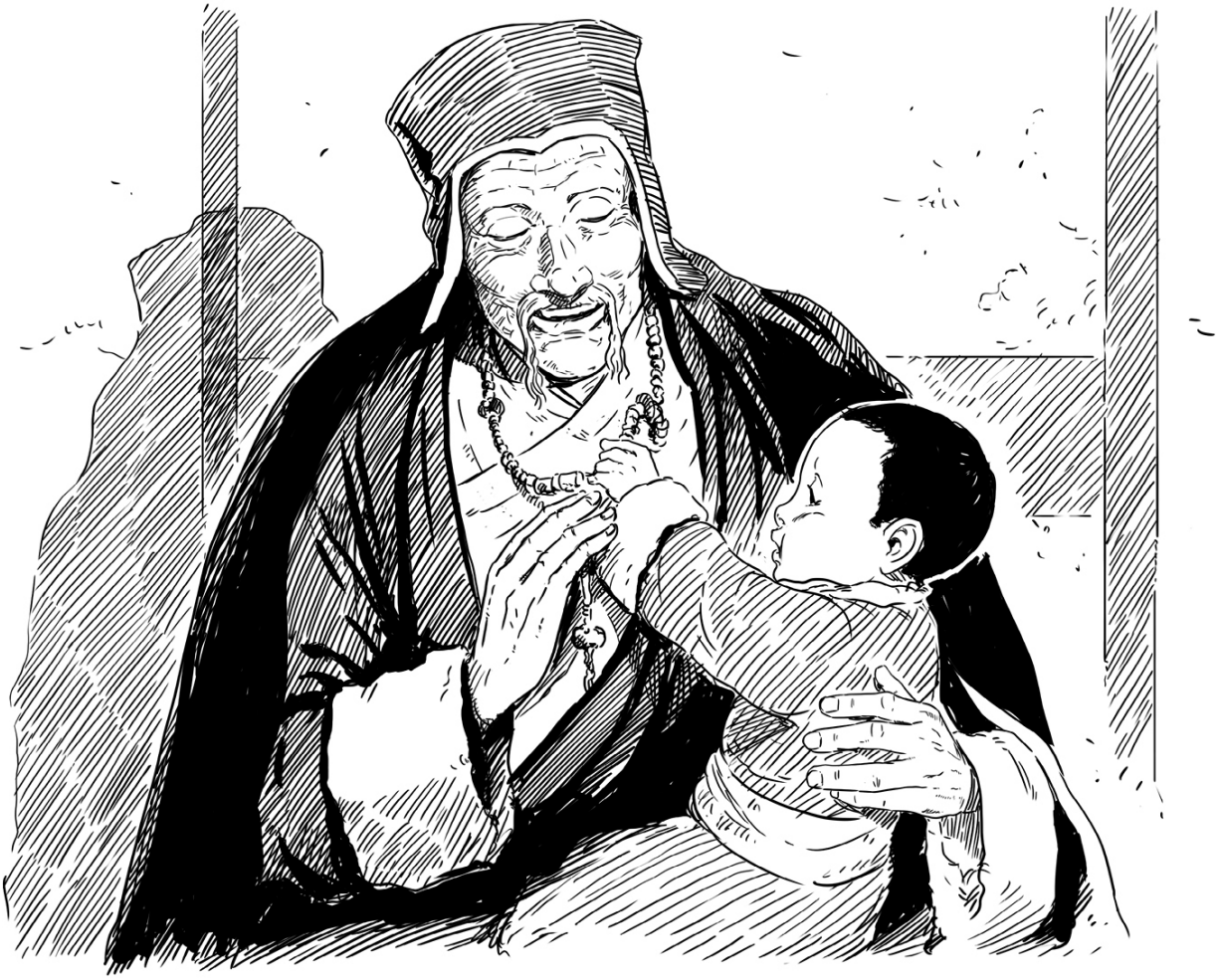


A few weeks later, the men returned. When Khetsang Rinpoche, a high-ranking lama, sat down in their kitchen, Lhamo jumped onto his lap. “I recognized many of them,” he later said, “although I had never met them.” Two-and-a-half-year-old Lhamo grabbed at the prayer beads around Khetsang’s neck. He wanted them. The beads had belonged to the previous Dalai Lama. Khetsang saw this as a sign that Lhamo might be the Thirteenth Dalai Lama’s reincarnation.

But Khetsang and his men needed to test Lhamo to be sure. They showed him different objects, including prayer beads and small drums. Some of the items had belonged to the Thirteenth Dalai Lama, while the others did not. The men waited. If Lhamo did indeed have the soul of the last Dalai Lama, he would recognize the correct items as his own. Lhamo chose all the right ones. Later, he said, “This may seem mysterious and even magical for most people, but when I saw those objects what I felt was